



select before each race. Money is used to purchase new rides or to upgrade cars you already own.

There are two types of race tracks in *Dirt 2*—traditional rally circuits that are completely off-road, dirt tracks and hybrid tracks that are a combination of dirt and tarmac sections. There are several event types available on these two tracks—circuit races, last man standing, one-on-one challenges, rally, etc. There is another race type worth mentioning called Gate Crasher where the objective is to achieve the fastest lap and smash through as many “gates” as you can.

All the races on the map essentially add up to be qualifiers for bigger events like the X-Games and World Championship events. Winning these big events reaps a major payout in terms of cash, XP and sometimes even new rides.

The Bounty and the Beast

Other bonus rewards come in the form of liveries (skin) for cars, dashboard and windshield toys, horn types and rally partners.

When you sum all this up, there is plenty in the game to keep an average gamer busy for about 15- 20 hours. For

me, the best experience was racing in rally events—essentially racing solo in a point-to-point event over some beautifully crafted tracks. The game's graphic engine does a pretty good job at delivering the whole experience of racing through the rugged race tracks. You get to race through wilderness of Malaysia, deserts of Morocco, gravel-filled roads in China.

Perhaps word of caution to casual racers— even on lowered difficulty level, the game keeps you on the edge. Being the first to cross the finish line requires a touch of finesse— push your car in one direction too hard and you'll find your car spinning out of control. The “Flashback” feature of this game comes as a savior for the lesser-skilled racers such as me.

For a limited number of times, the game allows you to correct your mistakes by letting you “rewinding” the race within a specific timeframe. In absence of this feature of course, one mistake could potentially compel you to completely restart the race. The number of Flashbacks available per race and varying degrees of driving assists are available depending on the difficulty level you choose before each level. These features combine to do an admirable job at satisfying the casual racers, Zen masters of racing and everyone in between.



Pole Position

Overall my experience with *Dirt 2* was quite enjoyable, although there were times when I wished those Buggies were not so damn difficult to handle. Thankfully, the way the events are setup, you can avoid certain races and still achieve major landmarks in your career. There is a good variety of vehicles in this game.

In spite of near 4 GB installation on the PS3, there were instances of texture pop-ins. Also, the relatively high load-times are especially unpleasant during multiple race events like the World Championship— often times, the rush from a previous race is lost staring at the loading screen. I recommend this game; especially to those that are looking for something that is right in between an arcade-style racer like *NFS* or *Midnight Club* and racing simulations like *Gran Turismo* or *Forza Motorsports*.

